

Topic: Social Change

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Definition of Social Change

- Social change is the process through which social structures and institutions are reconstructed, undergoing a cultural transformation.
- According to M. E Jones, social change occurs when social processes, social patterns, social interactions or social organizations encounter modifications from their everyday functioning.
- Jon. M. Shepard said that “Social change is the alteration in social structures that have long-term and relatively important consequences.”

Factors of social change

- ❖ Physical Environment
- ❖ Demographic (biological) Factor
- ❖ Cultural Factor
- ❖ Psychological Factor
- ❖ Economic Factor
- ❖ Political Factor
- ❖ Technological Factor

Linear theories of Social Change

- The notion of social evolution which is used in linear theories was taken from the theories of biological evolution.
- Some theorists which have employed a Linear Model or Evolutionary Model include Comte, Tylor, Spencer, Morgan, Hobhouse, Marx, Durkheim, Tonnies etc.
- The evolutionary theory of social change gained prominence in the 19th century.
- Sociologists latched on to Darwin's theory of evolution, applying it to society. Auguste Comte, known as the “father of sociology,” believed in the evolutionary model.

Linear theories of Social Change (continue)

Auguste Comte

- Comte used a progressive sequence accounting for new forms in his 'Law of the Three Stages'. These stages of history were designated theological, metaphysical, and positivistic.
- In theological stage, thinking was guided by religious ideas and beliefs that society was an expression of God's will.
- Metaphysical stage started with Renaissance in which society was seen in natural terms.
- Positivistic stage started with new scientific discoveries. Comte believed that eventually man would be able to measure empirically and explain conclusively all forms of social behavior in the latter stage.
- Another aspect of his idea of social change is that some aspects remain constant which he termed as 'social statics' and some change which he described through 'social dynamics'.

Linear theories of Social Change (continue)

Herbert Spencer

- Spencer took a classic evolutionary view and he often termed as a 'Social Darwinist' as his ideas were influenced by biological theory of evolution offered by Darwin.
- According to him evolution involves differentiation of simple things into complex or differentiated things. He also believed in the idea of 'survival of the fittest'. According to him, like organisms, societies are also made up of large number of interconnected parts and these parts evolve into more complex ones as needs of society grow. He also identified certain stages of evolution of societies – simple, compound, doubly compound and trebly compound.

Linear theories of Social Change (continue)

- Tonnies – a German sociologist – used Gemeinschaft and Gesellschaft to account for the same phenomena. These two social groups exist due to existence of two types of will viz – ‘Essential will’ and ‘Arbitrary will’. Essential will is associated with peasants and artisans, while arbitrary will is associated with businessmen, scientists, political class etc. People of groups belonging to the first type of will are called Gemeinschaft or community and those associated with the latter are called Gesellschaft or society. Societies also evolve from Gemeinschaft to Gesellschaft.

Cyclical theories of social change

- “Cyclical theories of social change focus on the rise and fall of civilizations attempting to discover and account for these patterns of growth and decay” – (Ian Robertson). Spengler, Toynbee and Sorokin can be regarded as the Champions of this theory. Their ideas may be briefed here.

Spengler: ‘The Destiny of Civilizations’

- Oswald Spengler, a German school teacher, in his book “The Decline of the West”-1918, pointed out that the fate of civilizations was a matter of “destiny”. Each civilization is like a biological organism and has a similar life-cycle; birth, maturity old age and death.
- After making a study of eight major civilizations, including the West, he said that the modern Western Society is in the last stage, i.e. old age. He concluded that the Western Societies were entering a period of decay – as evidenced by wars, conflicts, and social breakdown that heralded their doom.
- This theory is almost out of fashion today. His idea of ‘destiny’ is hardly an adequate explanation of social change. His biological analogy is also too unrealistic and his work is too mystical and speculative.

Cyclical theories of social change (continue)

Toynbee: ‘Challenge and Response’

- Arnold Toynbee, a British historian with enough sociological insight has offered a somewhat more promising a theory of social change. His famous book “A Study of History”-1946, a multivolume work, draws on materials from 24 civilizations.
- The key—concepts in Toynbee’s theory are those of “challenge and response”. “Every society faces challenges-at first, challenges posed by the environment; later challenges from internal and external enemies.
- The nature of the responses determines the society’s fate. The achievements of a civilization consist of its successful responses to challenges; if it cannot mount an effective response, it dies”.- (Ian Robertson).
- Toynbee’s views are more optimistic than those of Spengler’s, for he does not believe that all civilizations will inevitably decay. He has pointed out that history is a series of cycles of decay and growth. But each new civilization is able to learn from the mistakes and tomorrow from cultures of others.

Cyclical theories of social change (continue)

- It is, therefore, possible for each new cycle to offer higher levels of achievement. Still he has not explained why some societies are able to offer effective responses to their challenges while others do not, or why a society should overcome one challenge but become a victim of another.